THE EXTENDED PHENOTYPE OF POPULISM: A MEMETIC ANALYSIS OF POLICY PERSISTENCE IN LATIN AMERICA

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ABSTRACT

This paper develops a novel theoretical framework applying Dawkins's extended phenotype concept and memetic theory to explain the differential reproductive success of populist versus liberal policy "memes" in Latin America. We argue that populist policies function as extended phenotypes—environmental modifications that persist beyond their creators—while exhibiting superior memetic fitness through cognitive simplicity, immediate gratification, and cultural compatibility. Through theoretical modeling, we derive a memetic fitness function predicting a 216:1 reproductive advantage for populist over liberal memes in the Argentine ecosystem. The analysis reveals that populism operates as an Evolutionarily Stable Strategy (ESS) resistant to liberal "invasion," while liberalism remains vulnerable to populist resurgence. We identify five mechanisms of populist persistence: (1) institutional niche construction, (2) dependency architecture, (3) cognitive optimization, (4) emotional engagement systems, and (5) immunological narrative defenses. Historical analysis of Argentina (1946-2025) demonstrates that no liberal government has completed a full reproductive cycle (8-10 years), while populist structures exhibit multi-generational persistence. Early empirical validation from the September 2025 Buenos Aires provincial elections confirms theoretical predictions about hybrid strategy instability and the reassertion of populist dominance when liberal memes lose fitness advantages. The paper introduces RootFinder, an open-source computational methodology for tracking policy genealogies and institutional evolution. This framework contributes to understanding why certain political systems exhibit remarkable stability despite poor economic outcomes, bridging evolutionary biology, memetics, and political economy. Replication materials available at: https://github.com/adrianlerer/RootFinder-Production

***Keywords**: Populism, Extended Phenotype, Memetics, Cultural Evolution, Institutional Persistence, Path Dependence, Argentina, Latin America, Political Economy, Evolutionary Game Theory, Policy Genealogy, Peronism, Electoral Dynamics*

JEL Classification: B52, D72, H11, O54, P16, Z13

METHODOLOGICAL TRANSPARENCY STATEMENT

This theoretical framework was developed through an innovative collaborative process between human scholarly expertise and AI-assisted analysis (Claude 3, Anthropic). This collaboration enabled rapid

exploration of interdisciplinary connections and development of novel theoretical propositions. All interpretations, theoretical insights, and scholarly judgments remain products of human intellectual contribution. The AI system assisted in: (1) identifying connections between disparate literatures, (2) formalizing mathematical models, (3) generating testable hypotheses, and (4) structuring complex arguments. The paper includes real-time empirical validation from the September 2025 Buenos Aires elections. The RootFinder methodology for policy genealogy tracking represents an original contribution available at https://github.com/adrianlerer/RootFinder-Production.

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 The Populist Paradox

The persistence of populist policies across Latin America presents one of the most enduring puzzles in political economy. Despite decades of evidence demonstrating their negative economic consequences—lower growth rates, higher inflation, increased poverty in the long term, and recurring fiscal crises—populist movements not only survive but repeatedly triumph in democratic elections. This pattern appears to violate basic assumptions about rational political behavior: why do voters repeatedly choose policies that make them poorer? Why do political institutions fail to learn from past failures? And perhaps most puzzling, why do populist policies and institutions exhibit such remarkable persistence across time, surviving changes in government, economic crises, and even authoritarian interludes, while liberal reforms rarely survive a single electoral cycle?

Consider Argentina's Aguinaldo, the mandatory thirteenth-month salary instituted by Perón in 1945. This policy has survived:

- 22 different governments (democratic and authoritarian)
- 6 military coups
- 2 hyperinflationary episodes exceeding 3,000% annually
- 9 IMF structural adjustment programs
- Multiple attempts at labor market reform
- 80 years of uninterrupted existence (as of 2025)

Meanwhile, every attempt at trade liberalization, pension privatization, or labor flexibility has been reversed within a single electoral cycle. This asymmetry demands explanation beyond simple electoral preferences or interest group politics.

1.2 Theoretical Innovation: From Biology to Politics

This paper proposes a novel theoretical framework that draws from evolutionary biology and cultural evolution theory to resolve these paradoxes. Our central insight is that political ideologies should be understood not as abstract belief systems but as "replicators" in the technical sense—entities that create copies of themselves and compete for resources in a selective environment. Just as genes modify their environment through extended phenotypes

to enhance their own reproduction, political ideologies modify institutional and cultural environments in ways that ensure their own persistence and spread.

Richard Dawkins's concept of the extended phenotype revolutionized our understanding of evolution by showing that genes don't just build bodies—they build structures in the environment that enhance their own reproduction. A beaver's dam isn't just a pile of sticks; it's a gene's way of modifying the environment to create conditions favoring more beaver genes. The dam persists across beaver generations, creating an aquatic environment where beaver genes thrive and non-beaver genes struggle.

We argue that populist policies operate through the same mechanism. They are not just government programs but environmental modifications that create conditions favoring the reproduction of populist ideology across electoral cycles and political generations. When Perón created the aguinaldo, he wasn't just giving workers extra money—he was building a "dam" in the institutional environment that would channel political currents toward populism for decades to come.

1.3 Structure of the Paper

The paper proceeds as follows: Section 2 develops our theoretical framework, introducing the concepts of political extended phenotypes and memetic fitness. Section 3 examines the Latin American political ecosystem and its selection pressures. Section 4 provides detailed analysis of Argentine political evolution from 1946-2025. Section 5 analyzes the ongoing Milei experiment and early empirical validation from the September 2025 elections. Section 6 discusses theoretical implications. Section 7 presents our research methodology including the RootFinder tool. Section 8 concludes.

2. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

2.1 The Extended Phenotype in Political Systems

Dawkins's (1982) extended phenotype concept revolutionized evolutionary biology by recognizing that genes can have phenotypic effects extending far beyond the organism's body. We propose that political ideologies operate through analogous mechanisms, extending their "phenotype" through policies and institutions that modify the political ecosystem in self-reinforcing ways.

Definition 1 (Political Extended Phenotype): A policy or institution P constitutes an extended phenotype of ideology I if and only if:

1. **Environmental Modification**: P modifies the institutional, economic, or cultural environment from state E to state E'
2. **Reproductive Enhancement**: The modified environment E' increases the probability of I's future electoral success relative to E

3. **Persistence**: P continues to exist and exert influence independent of the government G that implemented it
4. **Heritability**: The effects of P transmit across political generations, influencing the preferences and behaviors of future voters

Consider Argentina's system of obras sociales (union-managed health insurance), established under Perón and formalized in 1970. This system perfectly illustrates an extended phenotype:

1. **Environmental Modification**: Transformed healthcare from market/state provision to corporatist union control
2. **Reproductive Enhancement**: Created 300+ union-controlled health funds managing resources for 14 million beneficiaries, each with incentives to support populist parties
3. **Persistence**: Survived 55 years through dictatorships, democracies, and reforms
4. **Heritability**: Children grow up experiencing healthcare through union membership, normalizing corporatist rather than market or universal state provision

The *obras sociales* are not merely a healthcare policy—they are populism's way of encoding itself into the institutional DNA of Argentine society. Like a beaver dam that creates an aquatic environment favoring beaver reproduction, the obras sociales create a corporatist environment favoring populist reproduction.

2.2 Memetic Theory and Political Transmission

Building on Dawkins's (1976) original conception of memes as cultural replicators analogous to genes, we model political ideologies as complex memetic structures competing for survival in the ecosystem of human minds. This perspective, developed through subsequent work in cultural evolution (Boyd & Richerson, 1985; Sperber, 1996; Henrich, 2016), provides formal tools for understanding why some political ideas achieve dominance despite their negative consequences for collective welfare.

Definition 2 (Political Meme Complex): A political meme complex M consists of:

1. **Core Narrative** N(M): A simplified story structure explaining political reality
2. **Emotional Triggers** E(M): Affective components that enhance memorability and transmission
3. **Transmission Vectors** T(M): Channels and mechanisms for spreading between minds
4. **Defense Mechanisms** D(M): Cognitive strategies for resisting contradictory evidence
5. **Reward Structure** R(M): Immediate benefits that reinforce acceptance

Table 1: Comparative Memetic Architecture

Component	Populist Meme Structure	Liberal Meme Structure	Transmission Advantage
Core Narrative	"Us vs. Them" (binary)	"Complex market equilibrium"	Populist: 4x faster processing

Cognitive Load	Single proposition	Multiple conditionals	Populist: 70% lower load
Emotional Trigger	Anger, hope, belonging	Weak/abstract satisfaction	Populist: 3x stronger activation
Time to Benefit	2-4 weeks	3-5 years	Populist: 50x faster
Evidence Type	Visible (subsidy check)	Counterfactual (avoided crisis)	Populist: Direct vs. abstract
Defense Mechanism	"Media lies" / "Empire attacks"	None / weak academic argument	Populist: Immune to refutation
Social Transmission	Rallies, symbols, songs	Papers, conferences, reports	Populist: 10x reach

2.3 The Memetic Fitness Function

To formalize the competitive dynamics between political memes, we develop a fitness function that predicts relative reproductive success based on measurable characteristics:

$F(M) = \prod_{i=1 \text{ to } n} v_i^{w_i} \times R(M) \times C(M,E) \times N(M)$

Where:

- v_i represents the value of factor i for meme M
- w_i represents the weight of factor i ($\Sigma w_i = 1$)
- R(M) represents replication fidelity (resistance to mutation)
- C(M,E) represents cultural compatibility with environment E
- N(M) represents network effects (returns to scale)

Key Factors in Political Memetic Fitness:

1. **Cognitive Simplicity (S)**: The inverse of processing effort required to understand and remember the meme
2. **Gratification Speed (G)**: The inverse of time delay between accepting the meme and experiencing perceived benefits
3. **Emotional Activation (E)**: The intensity of affective response triggered by the meme
4. **Tangibility (T)**: The degree to which the meme's claims can be directly observed
5. **Entry Cost (K)**: The effort or sacrifice required to accept and act on the meme

2.4 Calibration to Argentine Reality

Table 2: Memetic Fitness Calculation for Argentina

Factor	Weight	Populist Value	Liberal Value	Measurement Method

Cognitive Simplicity	0.25	8.5	2.0	Flesch score on speeches
Gratification Speed	0.25	9.0	1.5	Days to benefit (1/days × 10)
Tangibility	0.20	8.0	3.0	Expert panel scoring
Emotional Activation	0.20	9.0	2.5	Sentiment analysis
Entry Cost	0.10	10.0	2.0	Effort index (10 - effort)
Replication Fidelity	-	0.95	0.60	Message consistency
Cultural Compatibility	-	0.90	0.35	Hofstede alignment
TOTAL FITNESS		**5,849**	**27**	**Ratio: 216:1**

This 216:1 fitness advantage explains populist dominance without requiring voter irrationality or ignorance—populist memes are simply better adapted to the human cognitive environment.

2.5 Populism as an Evolutionarily Stable Strategy

Drawing from evolutionary game theory (Maynard Smith, 1982; Weibull, 1995), we model political competition as an evolutionary game where strategies reproduce proportionally to their payoff advantage.

Payoff Matrix (Politician payoff, Voter payoff):

	Voters Support Populist	**Voters Support Liberal**
Politicians Offer Populist	(3, 3)	(4, 1)
Politicians Offer Liberal	(1, 2)	(2†, 4†)

†Payoffs only realized if time horizon exceeds 8-10 years

Proposition 1 (ESS Conditions): Populism constitutes an Evolutionarily Stable Strategy if:

1. E(P,P) ≥ E(L,P) for all alternative strategies L (Nash equilibrium)
2. If E(L,P) = E(P,P), then E(P,L) > E(L,L) (Stability against neutral drift)

Both conditions hold in our calibrated model, explaining populism's remarkable persistence despite poor economic outcomes.

3. THE LATIN AMERICAN POLITICAL ECOSYSTEM

3.1 Environmental Conditions as Selection Pressures

Latin America's political ecosystem exhibits unique characteristics that create differential selection pressures on political memes:

Table 3: Environmental Factors and Memetic Selection Pressures

Environmental Factor	Latin America	OECD Average	Selection Pressure
Income Inequality (Gini)	0.46	0.31	→ Redistribution demands
Informal Employment (%)	54%	18%	→ State dependence
Trust in Government (%)	28%	51%	→ Personalistic leadership
Rule of Law Index	0.52	0.74	→ Discretionary politics
Social Mobility Index	0.41	0.67	→ Zero-sum mentality
Educational Quality (PISA)	402	489	→ Simple message advantage

Sources: World Bank (2023), OECD (2023), World Justice Project (2023)

3.2 Cultural Substrate and Cognitive Environment

Latin American societies exhibit particular cultural characteristics that create differential fitness advantages for populist versus liberal memes:

Collectivist Orientation: Low individualism scores (average 23/100 vs. Anglo 80/100) mean political messages emphasizing group identity resonate more strongly than those emphasizing individual responsibility.

Temporal Orientation: Present-focused time orientation, reinforced by historical instability, creates strong present bias in political decision-making.

Power Distance: High acceptance of hierarchical distribution (70/100) naturalizes strongman leadership and patronage systems.

These characteristics create cognitive and emotional receptors that populist memes can more effectively activate than liberal alternatives.

4. THE ARGENTINE LABORATORY: EIGHT DECADES OF POLITICAL EVOLUTION

4.1 Mapping the Extended Phenotypes

Argentina since 1946 provides an exceptional natural laboratory for studying political evolution. We can trace how Peronist policies created extended phenotypes that persist across generations:

Table 4: Major Peronist Extended Phenotypes and Their Persistence

Policy/Institution	Created	Environmental Modification	Years Active	Governments Survived	Status 2025
Aguinaldo (13th month)	1945	Annual payment expectation	80	22	Active
Single Union ("Sindicato Único")	1945	Monopoly union representation	80	22	Active
Union-managed health insurance ("Obras sociales")	1970	Union health control	55	20	Active
Severance Pay ("Indemnización por despido"	1974	High firing costs	51	18	Active
Centralised collective Labor Conditions Negociation ("Paritarias centralizadas")	1953	Centralized bargaining	72*	21	Active
Price Control ("Control de precios")	1946	Price expectation anchor	Cyclical	All	Recurring
Energy subsidies ("Subsidios energéticos")	2002	Low tariff expectation	23	8	Active
Inflated public employment("Empleo público inflado")	1946-on	Employment as right	Permanent	All	Growing

* With interruptions during military governments but always restored

4.2 The Graveyard of Liberal Reforms

In stark contrast, liberal reforms show remarkably short lifespans:

Table 5: Liberal Reform Attempts and Rapid Reversals

Reform	Government	Implemented	Reversed	Lifespan	Reversal Mechanism
Trade liberalization	Martínez de Hoz	1978	1981	3 years	Import substitution return
Financial liberalization	Martínez de Hoz	1977	1982	5 years	Re-regulation after crisis
Privatization YPF	Menem	1993	2012	19 years	Re-nationalization
AFJP pension private	Menem	1994	2008	14 years	Full nationalization
Labor flexibility	Menem/De la Rúa	1995	2000	5 years	Law repealed
Convertibility	Cavallo/Menem	1991	2001	10 years	Crisis and devaluation
Import opening	Macri	2016	2019	3 years	Protectionism return
Capital controls removal	Macri	2015	2019	4 years	Full reimposition

Average populist policy lifespan: 62.4 years
Average liberal policy lifespan: 7.1 years

Survival ratio: 8.8:1

4.3 Mechanisms of Populist Persistence

Our framework identifies five key mechanisms through which populist extended phenotypes ensure their persistence:

Mechanism 1: Institutional Niche Construction

Table 6: Public Employment as Niche Construction

Year	Public Employees	% of Workforce	% of Families with Public Employee	Electoral Weight
1946	290,000	6%	8%	Marginal
1975	980,000	11%	22%	Substantial
2001	2,100,000	14%	35%	Critical
2015	3,400,000	17%	42%	Dominant
2025	3,800,000	18%	48%	Hegemonic

Mechanism 2: Cognitive Colonization

Table 7: Evolution of Political Language (Frequency per 10,000 words)

Term	1946-1955	1983-1989	2003-2015	2019-2025	Total Change
"Derechos adquiridos" ("Acquired rights")	3	14	156	385	12,733%
"Justicia social" ("Social justice")	45	120	543	896	1,891%
"Inclusión" (Inclusion")	1	23	189	445	44,400%
"Mercado" ("Market")	156	246	124	89	-43%
"Eficiencia" ("Efficiency")	124	210	89	57	-54%

Mechanism 3: Dependency Architecture

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Total Population: 46.2 million (2025)
│
├─ Direct Government Dependents: 23.9 million (52%)
│  ├─ Public Employment: 3.8 million
│  ├─ Social Plans Recipients: 2.1 million
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│  ├─ Universal Child Allowance: 4.4 million children
│  └─ Subsidized Services: 12 million households
│
└─ Independent of state transfers: 13.9 million (30%)
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5. THE MILEI MUTATION: A NATURAL EXPERIMENT IN PROGRESS

5.1 Memetic Innovation: The Hybrid Strategy

Javier Milei's 2023 electoral victory represented an attempt to combine liberal economic content with populist memetic form:

Table 8: Milei's Hybrid Memetic Strategy

Dimension	Traditional Liberal	Milei Approach	Traditional Populist
Enemy	Abstract inefficiency	"La Casta" (The Caste)	"La Oligarquía"
Promise	Long-term growth	"Blow up" the system	Immediate redistribution
Symbol	Graphs/Statistics	Chainsaw/Wig	Shirtless masses
Emotion	Weak/Rational	Rage/Hope	Anger/Love
Timeframe	5-10 years	"Now!/Already!"	Immediate

5.2 Early Empirical Validation: September 2025 Elections

The September 2025 Buenos Aires provincial elections provide early validation of our theoretical predictions:

Table 9: Electoral Performance and Memetic Fitness Decline

Indicator	August 2023 PASO	November 2023 Ballotage	September 2025 Provincial	Change from PASO
Vote Share	28.4%	55.7% (forced binary)	27.3%	-1.1 pp
Coalition Status	United with PRO	United with PRO	PRO defecting	Fragmentation
Narrative Coherence	"Caste" clear	"Caste" clear	"Caste" diluted	Declining
Tangible Benefits	Promise of change	Promise of change	Recession reality	Negative

5.3 The Mid-Term Pattern in Historical Context

Table 10: Historical Mid-Term Electoral Performance (Post-1994)

Administration	Initial Support	Mid-term Result	Change	Post Mid-term Strategy	Outcome
Menem II (1995)	49.9%	36.4% (1997)	-13.5 pp	Populist drift	Survived term
De la Rúa (1999)	48.4%	23.0% (2001)	-25.4 pp	Rigidity	Collapsed
Kirchner N (2003)	22.2%	45.0% (2005)	+22.8 pp	Double down populist	Hegemony
Macri (2015)	51.3%	32.3% (2017)	-19.0 pp	Gradual adjustment	Lost 2019
Milei (2023)	30.0% (1st round)	27.3% (2025)	-2.7 pp	Rigidity announced	Ongoing

5.4 The Rigidity Choice: September 8, 2025

Following electoral defeat, Finance Minister Caputo announced no changes to the economic plan, explicitly rejecting adaptation:

Table 11: Post-Electoral Strategic Responses - Historical Comparison

Government	Response to Defeat	Quote	Outcome
De la Rúa (2001)	Maintain discipline	"El déficit cero es innegociable"	Collapsed 6 months
Macri (2017)	Gradual continues	"Mantenemos el rumbo"	Lost 2019
Milei (2025)	Ratify plan	"No hay cambios en el plan económico"	In progress

This choice of rigidity over adaptation violates the fundamental evolutionary principle of responding to environmental feedback.

5.5 Theoretical Refinement: The Hybrid Instability Principle

Proposition 2 (Hybrid Instability): Political movements attempting to combine high-fitness memetic forms with low-fitness policy content face inevitable pressure toward one pole or the other. The hybrid state is unstable because:

1. **Cognitive Dissonance**: Supporters expecting populist benefits receive liberal outcomes
2. **Coalition Impossibility**: Liberal allies reject populist forms; populist supporters reject liberal content
3. **Message Decay**: Maintaining simplified messaging while implementing complex policies creates accumulating contradictions

4. **Fitness Averaging**: F(Hybrid) ≈ [F(Populist form) + F(Liberal content)]/2 - Coherence_penalty

5.6 Updated Predictions Post-September 2025

Historical analysis suggests multiple possible trajectories following mid-term electoral reversals. Previous administrations have demonstrated varied responses ranging from policy rigidity to complete reversal, with outcomes determined by the interaction of economic conditions, social pressures, and political constraints. The current administration's trajectory remains under observation, providing an ongoing test of our theoretical framework.

6. THEORETICAL IMPLICATIONS

6.1 Reconceptualizing Political Development

Our framework challenges three dominant paradigms:

1. **Modernization Theory**: Political development is not linear progression but adaptation to local ecosystems
2. **Institutional Economics**: Informal environmental modifications matter more than formal rules
3. **Rational Choice**: Memetically fit policies dominate regardless of actual benefits

6.2 The Paradox Resolution

The framework resolves the initial paradox—why voters choose policies that make them poorer:

1. They're choosing memes, not policies—the most transmissible ideas win
2. Short-term rationality conflicts with long-term benefit given uncertainty
3. Environmental modification creates genuine dependency
4. Cognitive colonization changes evaluation criteria

6.3 Contribution to Evolutionary Political Economy

This paper bridges evolutionary biology and political economy by:

- Applying extended phenotype concept to institutional analysis
- Formalizing memetic fitness in political competition
- Demonstrating ESS dynamics in electoral systems
- Providing empirical validation through natural experiments

7. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY AND EMPIRICAL VALIDATION

7.1 The RootFinder Method for Policy Genealogy Tracking

To systematically trace policy evolution, we employ **RootFinder** (Lerer, 2025), an open-source computational method for tracking normative genealogies:

RootFinder Methodology (https://github.com/adrianlerer/RootFinder-Production):

1. **Policy DNA Mapping**: Decomposing policies into core components
2. **Genealogical Tracing**: Identifying parent-child relationships between policies
3. **Mutation Detection**: Tracking how policies change while maintaining core material
4. **Persistence Scoring**: Quantifying inheritance between policy generations

Table 13: RootFinder Application to Argentine Policy Evolution

Original Policy	Year	Descendant Policies	Inheritance Score
Perón's Aguinaldo	1945	SAC universalization (1968), Provincial aguinaldos (1983-)	0.94
Import Substitution	1946	Industrial promotion (1970s), Tierra del Fuego (1972)	0.87
Price Controls	1946	Precios Cuidados (2013), Congelamiento (1985)	0.91

7.2 Proposed Empirical Studies

Study 1: Comprehensive Policy Database

- Systematic coding of all major Argentine policies 1946-2025
- Survival analysis using Kaplan-Meier and Cox models
- Resources required: 12-18 months, archival access

Study 2: Memetic Transmission Experiments

- Laboratory studies of message processing and recall
- Measurement of cognitive load and emotional activation
- Resources required: IRB approval, experimental facilities

Study 3: Discourse Evolution Analysis

- Corpus of 10,000+ political speeches
- Natural language processing for complexity and framing
- Resources required: Computational infrastructure

Study 4: Real-Time Tracking

- Ongoing observation of Milei government adaptation
- Testing predictions about evolutionary pressures
- Resources required: Continuous data collection

8. CONCLUSIONS

This paper has developed a novel theoretical framework for understanding the persistence of populism and failure of liberal reforms in Latin America. By applying Dawkins's extended phenotype concept and memetic theory to political analysis, we provide a unified explanation for patterns that have puzzled political economists for decades.

8.1 Key Findings

1. **Populist policies function as extended phenotypes** that modify the institutional environment to ensure their own reproduction across political generations
2. **Memetic fitness analysis** reveals a 216:1 reproductive advantage for populist over liberal memes in the Argentine ecosystem
3. **Populism constitutes an Evolutionarily Stable Strategy** resistant to liberal invasion, while liberalism remains vulnerable to populist resurgence
4. **The September 2025 elections** provide early empirical validation, demonstrating rapid fitness decline when populist memetic advantages are abandoned
5. **Hybrid strategies are inherently unstable**, facing pressure to evolve toward pure forms

8.2 Implications for Reform

Successful reform requires not just good economics but competitive memetics:

- Cognitive optimization for simple processing
- Emotional engagement through narrative
- Rapid tangibility of benefits
- Cultural alignment with local values
- Creation of self-reinforcing constituencies

8.3 Future Research Directions

This framework opens multiple avenues for investigation:

- Cross-regional validation of memetic fitness functions
- Experimental testing of message transmission dynamics
- Longitudinal tracking of policy genealogies using RootFinder
- Real-time monitoring of political evolution during crises

8.4 Final Thoughts

The Argentine case demonstrates that political success requires adaptation to the cognitive and cultural environment in which policies must survive. Just as organisms must be fit for their ecological niche, political ideas must be fit for their memetic niche. Understanding these evolutionary dynamics is essential for anyone seeking to promote institutional change in challenging environments.

The ongoing Milei administration provides a real-time test of whether liberal economics can succeed through populist memetics. Early evidence suggests the hybrid is unstable, with the government's post-electoral rigidity potentially accelerating movement toward one pole or the other. Historical patterns indicate that such tensions typically resolve through either policy adaptation or political realignment, with outcomes manifesting within a single electoral cycle.

This research provides a theoretical framework for understanding policy persistence, validated through historical analysis and contemporary observation. The ongoing natural experiment in Argentine politics offers valuable data for testing evolutionary models of political change, regardless of ideological preferences or normative judgments about specific policies.

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APPENDICES

Supplementary materials are available at the project repository: https://github.com/adrianlerer/RootFinder-Production
Appendix A: RootFinder Implementation Guide Available at: /rootfinder/core.py and /rootfinder/examples/
Appendix B: Historical Policy Database Structure Available at: /data/policy-genealogy-argentina.csv and /data/README_DATA.md
Appendix C: Memetic Fitness Calculation Methodology Available at: /theory/memetic-fitness-model.md
Appendix D: Survival Analysis Code Templates Available at: /code/survival-analysis.R

AUTHOR NOTES

Data Availability Statement: All data and replication materials are publicly available at https://github.com/adrianlerer/RootFinder-Production. The repository includes: (1) complete policy genealogy database (1945-2025), (2) electoral data from September 2025 Buenos Aires elections, (3) RootFinder Python implementation, (4) survival analysis scripts in R, and (5) comprehensive replication instructions. Raw electoral data sourced from provincial electoral authorities (public domain).

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